

Exploring Differences Between Parents’ Perceptions and Mediation of ChatGPT and Social Media

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Research Questions

Do parents’ perceptions of ChatGPT differ from their perceptions of social media?

Do parents’ perceptions lead to different mediation strategies?

Background

ChatGPT is becoming increasingly popular among both children and adults¹
Parents use similar strategies to manage children’s social media & ChatGPT use^{2,3}, but **unknown if**:

- Parent **perceptions between social media and ChatGPT differ**
- Parent **perceptions of either lead to different mediation strategies at home**

Sample & Design

Sample: 12 U.S.-based families (at least one parent and one child 8-18 y/o) consisting of 14 participating parents (10 mothers & 4 fathers , 92% 4-yr degree or higher, 75% annual income >100k), 14 participating children (58% boys, 71% between 8-12 y/o)

Design: 60-120 min semi-structured qualitative interviews over Zoom conducted between Feb-May 2024

- At least one parent/child present during interview
- Questions about:
 - why & how they used ChatGPT
 - how they accessed ChatGPT
 - risks or benefits of ChatGPT
 - strategies for managing children’s ChatGPT use & other online activities

Analysis: Inductive thematic analysis⁴ w/ 2 coders (in results, P= parent, #= family ID; P#-1 or P#-2 if two parents)

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References

¹ Madden, M., Calvin, A., Hasse, A., & Lenhart, A. (2024). The dawn of the AI era: Teens, parents, and the adoption of generative AI at home and school. San Francisco, CA: Common Sense
² Abel, C., & Magnusson, M. (2024). Playdates & Algorithms: Exploring parental awareness and mediation strategies in the age of generative artificial intelligence.
³ Yu, Y., Sharma, T., Hu, M., Wang, J., & Wang, Y. (2024). Exploring Parent-Child Perceptions on Safety in Generative AI: Concerns, Mitigation Strategies, and Design Implications. arXiv preprint arXiv:2406.10461
⁴ Clarke, V., & Braun, V. (2014). Thematic analysis. In Encyclopedia of critical psychology (pp. 1947-1952). Springer, New York, NY.

Takeaway

Parents **felt that ChatGPT may pose fewer risks** to their children than social media, but also **highlighted unique concerns** about the platform they found **difficult to mediate**.

Overall, parents were less concerned about ChatGPT than social media (e.g., YouTube, Tiktok, Instagram, etc.), and parents’ concerns differed between ChatGPT and social media.

Notably, most parents saw **social media as entertainment platforms**, but thought of **ChatGPT as an information seeking tool** that could be used together for bonding & learning.

Top 3 concerns about social media

Inappropriate Interactions

“So then I went into the room and I asked him to mute, and I said, ‘who you’re [sic] talking to?’ He goes, ‘I don’t know, some kid in Connecticut,’ and I was like, ‘Okay, could you get off the game and we’ll talk?’” (P6)

Social Comparisons

“... the focus on appearance and the focus on presentation [concerns me]... the pressure on kids to [focus on those things] and then what they’re seeing from other people could affect their mental health.” (P11-2)

Algorithms & Excess Use

“I don’t know what the algorithm is for [YouTube], to go from one [video] to the next... I don’t know if he’s gonna see [something inappropriate].” (P2)

“[TikTok and Instagram] give you a couple of seconds of those... videos or music... you can keep scrolling for hours.” (P10)

What were the top 3 concerns about ChatGPT?

Here are the top 3 concerns parents mentioned:

1. Overreliance

“I think there’s the academic integrity impacts. And then just baseline writing ability and creativity stunting that might happen if you were to rely entirely on these [ChatGPT] models [to do the work rather] than to kind of create any sort of academic outputs that you’re being asked to do.” (P12)

2. Data Privacy & Transparency

“I don’t know if the risk is all the same [on all platforms], but also [ChatGPT is] collecting our data... there’s a different sort of risk to giving out personal information... the risk that somebody could hack it and read what you’re writing.” (P5)

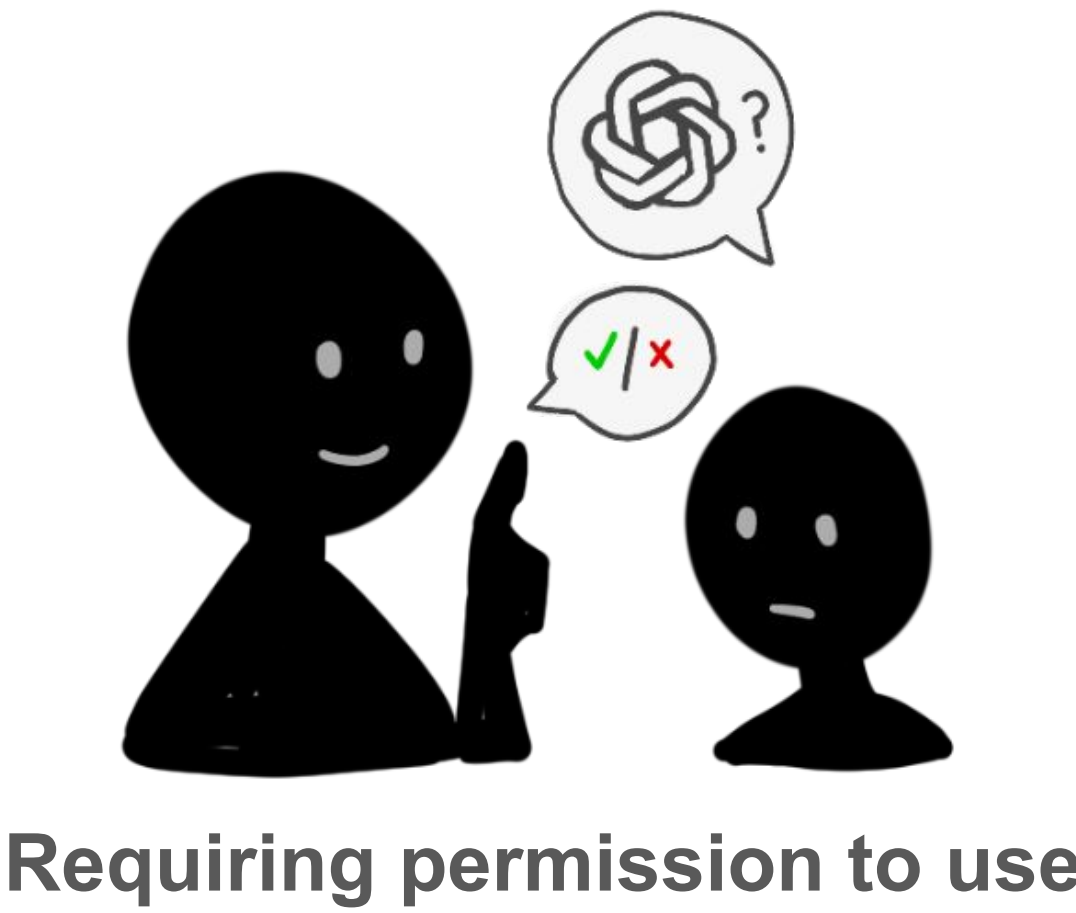
“[ChatGPT] didn’t cite sources or have sources of where some of the information was coming from.” (P9-1)

3. Inaccurate or Harmful Information

“I don’t think that [students] should fully trust that [ChatGPT’s answer] is the best answer that exists, and they should really be mindful of where all this [information] is being generated from and that it’s going to have issues.” (P8)

Overall, families mentioned fewer rules around using ChatGPT vs social media...

The two **most popular ChatGPT mediation strategies** were:



Though some parents struggled to adapt certain strategies they had for general online safety for ChatGPT.

